towards places outside the Great Indian Migration Wave which itself was reshaping away from South East Asia towards West Asia in the 1970s.

In the last quarter of the 20th century, West Asia, North America and Europe grew in prominence with more settlement taking place in the latter two regions. By 2010, a fifth of the Indian diaspora was based in North America and a tenth was based in Europe. The diaspora in the old hotspots of Africa and Latin America grew naturally, with little further immigration. With Nepal, migration across the porous border continued on both sides, especially for marriages. In recent decades, Singapore and Australia have emerged as important destinations for professional migration, while Italy has attracted over a 1,00,000 Indian immigrants, mainly in its agricultural sector.

The contemporary Indian diaspora of over 25 million people represents around 2 per cent of the Indian population. More than a third of this number is based in the English-speaking world. It forms less than 5 per cent of the local population in most countries: between 5 and 10 per cent in Malaysia and Singapore, between 10 and 20 per cent in some of the smaller Gulf countries and over a third of the population in many of the old sugar plantation-based economies. The Indian diaspora is large, diverse and complex, and spans the entire world. The old adage about the sun not setting on the British Empire now holds true for the Indian diaspora.

Sweet Dreams and Nightmares: The Sugar Plantations

It is often said in jest that when the sun did rise on the British Empire, it did so on a tremendous sugar rush.[4] The sugar plantations in the distant European colonies in the Caribbean islands and Latin America, the islands of the Indian Ocean such as Mauritius and Réunion, and the islands of the Pacific Ocean above Australia, such as Fiji, were important centres for the growth of colonialism and capitalism. Most of these colonies began with slave labour, only to be replaced by indentured labour in the early 19th century.